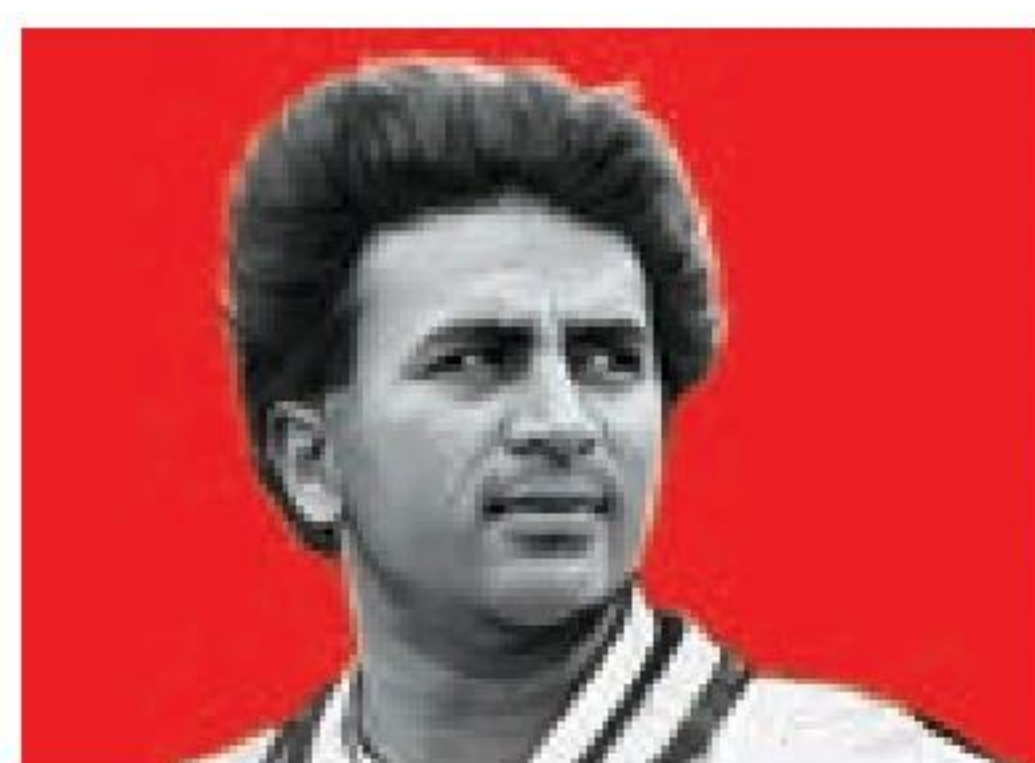




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



FOR MORE
STORIES

WHILE T20 IS A GAME MADE FOR SIXES, IT DOES NOT MEAN SLOGGERS WILL DOMINATE

With T20 leagues **mushrooming** in virtually every city, where the talent is pretty ordinary, it is easy for scouts to get carried away by some players' big-hitting.

At the time of writing, even as the final week of the league stage of the IPL starts, the four playoff qualifiers have not been decided. Yes, two teams, Mumbai Indians and Lucknow Super Giants, are out of the reckoning, but to get into the final week and still have eight teams in contention for the playoff places is perhaps an indication of how teams have levelled out over the years.

The young batting talent on display is exciting when they get going, to say the least. That said, these very same batters, when confronted with a slightly spicy pitch, are fending deliveries off their faces quite awkwardly. It makes you wonder if they will last the course in red-ball cricket, where bowlers are trying to get a batter out and not just looking to restrict the runs as in the limited-overs formats.

What this year's IPL has also done is once again expose the folly of

picking some batters on the basis of a single performance in the previous season. **With T20 leagues mushrooming in virtually every city, where the talent is pretty ordinary, it is easy for scouts to get carried away by some players' big-hitting.** On pitches where the ball hardly bounces above the midriff, and boundaries are half the size of the IPL grounds, it is easy to hit sixes and look good. Then, when one is bought for multi-crore figures and is confronted by international-quality bowlers on pitches with a little more bounce than city league pitches, along with bigger boundaries, the batter is thoroughly exposed. There is double pressure: the expectation created by the fee paid and the challenge of facing international-quality bowling.

Similarly, in bowling, on sub-standard pitches, one can look menacing, but on good pitches in the IPL, with bigger boundaries and against world-class batters, the pace

drops very quickly. In India, we tend to get excited if a bowler delivers at 145 kmph. Suddenly, he is called a sensation and whatnot. But real speed is above 150 kmph, and there are not too many bowlers who are able to do so consistently.

The fact is, most, if not all, these city leagues are nothing more than '*mohalla league*', where the overall standard is pretty low, and to think that a scout has unearthed the latest gem is to fool oneself. The gem is quickly exposed as glass. Most times, if the player has been fortunate enough to be in a bidding war and fetch crores, then not only does the pressure build, but there is also a visible relaxation of effort. The idea then is to just do enough to stay in the team and get another contract the following year.

The franchises seem to have learnt their lesson, albeit after a few seasons, and many a one-innings performer found himself ignored at the auction after one standout